

Overview: Attention Cues

Attention cues ensure you have the pupil's focus before you start speaking. For pupils who are easily distracted or have difficulties sustaining attention, instructions delivered without first securing attention simply don't land. Using the pupil's name, non-verbal signals like a touch on the desk or visual cue, and checking for attention before speaking transforms instruction delivery from hopeful to effective.

When to Use This Strategy

- Pupil frequently asks "What do I do?" immediately after instructions
- Starts wrong task or does nothing while others begin
- Looks at you but seems "elsewhere" mentally
- Responds better when you speak directly to them

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Use their name before the instruction

Say the pupil's name first. Pause briefly. Wait for them to look at you. Then give the instruction. This sequence—name, pause, instruction—is critical.

Teacher says: "Aiden." [Pause, wait for eye contact] "Open your book to page 12."

Tip: The pause is essential. Name-then-immediate-instruction doesn't work as well.

2 Establish a non-verbal attention cue

Agree a non-verbal signal with the pupil for when verbal cues would be disruptive or when they're deeply focused elsewhere. This could be a gentle touch on the desk, a tap near their book, or showing a small cue card.

Teacher says: "When I tap your desk like this, it means I need you to look at me. Let's practice."

Tip: Practice the cue when stakes are low so it becomes automatic.

3 Check for attention before speaking

Don't assume attention—verify it. Look for eye contact, body orientation toward you, or a verbal acknowledgement. If attention isn't there, use your cue again.

Teacher says: "Are you with me? Good. Here's what I need you to do..."

Tip: A quick "thumbs up if you're ready" works well for whole-class checks.

4 Position yourself effectively

Move close enough that your cue will work. Trying to gain attention from across the room rarely succeeds. Proximity supports attention.

Tip: Stand near the pupil during key instruction moments. Don't hover—just be close.

5 Establish a consistent routine

Make attention cues predictable. Use the same sequence every time. Predictability helps the pupil recognise when attention is needed.

Teacher says: "Remember, when you hear your name, stop, look at me, and listen."

6 Reinforce successful attention

When the pupil responds well to your attention cue, acknowledge it briefly. This builds the habit.

Teacher says: "Thank you, Aiden. Good looking. Now, here's what we're doing..."

Tip: Keep praise brief and move straight to the instruction.

English Example: Starting a comprehension task

Year 8 reading comprehension. One pupil frequently misses instructions because they're looking at their book or out the window when you speak to the class.

Gain attention before whole-class instruction

Teacher: Before addressing the class, move near the pupil. Tap desk gently. Wait for them to look up.

Pupil: Looks up from book. Makes eye contact.

Give whole-class instruction

Teacher: Now give the instruction to the class: "Everyone, read the passage on page 34 and answer questions 1 to 3."

Pupil: Hears the instruction because attention was already secured.

Check individual understanding

Teacher: After class instruction, check: "Mia, what page are we on?" Wait for response.

Pupil: Says "Page 34" confirming they heard.

Provide quick redirect if needed

Teacher: If pupil didn't catch it: "Page 34, questions 1 to 3. Start with question 1."

Pupil: Opens to correct page, begins reading.

Maths Example: Transitioning to independent practice

Year 7 maths lesson. After teaching input, pupils begin practice. One pupil with ADHD often continues looking at the board or fidgeting and misses the transition.

Use name to signal transition

Teacher: As lesson transitions, say clearly: "Kyle." Pause. Wait for response.

Pupil: Stops fidgeting. Looks at teacher.

Deliver clear instruction

Teacher: Say: "It's time to work on your own now. Questions 1 to 5 in your book."

Pupil: Hears instruction clearly because attention was secured first.

Point to resource

Teacher: Point to the textbook and the specific questions while close to the pupil.

Pupil: Opens book to correct page.

Check they've started

Teacher: After 30 seconds, return: "Kyle, which question are you on?" Brief check.

Pupil: Shows they've begun or receives quick redirect if stuck.

Science Example: Giving safety instructions during practical

Year 9 practical lesson. Pupil is excited about the equipment and is visually scanning the room, not attending to safety briefing.

Secure attention before safety instructions

Teacher: Stand near pupil. Say: "Jayden, this is important." Pause. Make eye contact.

Pupil: Stops scanning the room. Looks at teacher.

Deliver key safety point

Teacher: Say: "Goggles on before you touch any equipment. Tell me the rule."

Pupil: Says "Goggles on first" - confirming they heard and understood.

Use visual cue for ongoing attention

Teacher: Hold up the goggles as a visual anchor while explaining: "These stay on the whole time. Not on your forehead—on your eyes."

Pupil: Watches the goggles, attention maintained through visual focus.

Confirm understanding with action

Teacher: Say: "Show me. Put your goggles on now."

Pupil: Puts goggles on correctly, demonstrating they attended to instruction.